

Designing for equitable digital access

Orientation

EQUITABLE ACCESS IN CONTEXT

Access is determined at the design stage — not at delivery.

Programmes succeed only if people can realistically use them.

Digital programmes are often designed for an assumed “average” user.

In practice, access is shaped by context:

[01] Device ownership and control

[02] Connectivity stability

[03] Digital and language literacy

[04] Identity documentation

[05] Household power and decision-making

Small design assumptions can quietly exclude entire groups before implementation begins.

When structural access conditions are not addressed early:

[01] Uptake may fall below expectations

[02] Participation may skew toward already advantaged groups

[03] Monitoring data may mask exclusion

[04] Course correction becomes more complex and costly

WHERE ACCESS GAPS BEGIN

Small design assumptions can create large access gaps.

Structural risks

Structural risk refers to programme design choices that unintentionally exclude people before implementation begins.

Examples of structural risk

- [01]

Assuming smartphone ownership
- [02]

Requiring online ID verification
- [03]

Designing text-heavy interfaces in low-literacy contexts
- [04]

Ignoring gender gaps in device control
- [05]

Using digital-only systems in areas with unstable connectivity

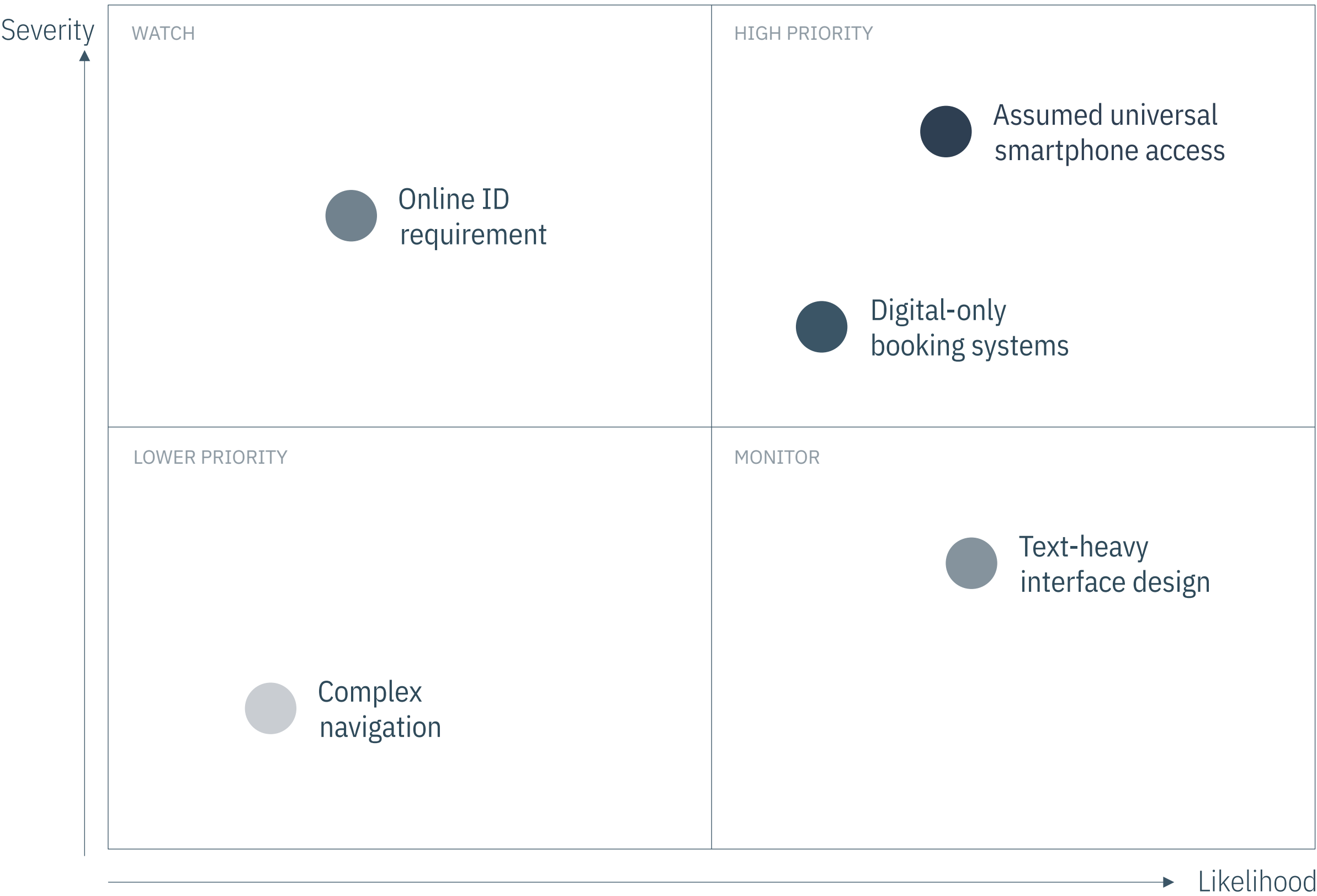
These risks are often invisible at funding or proposal stage but determine real-world access later.

PRIORITISING STRUCTURAL RISKS

Not all access risks
carry the same weight.

Assessing structural risks

This slide illustrates how structural risks can be assessed before implementation begins.



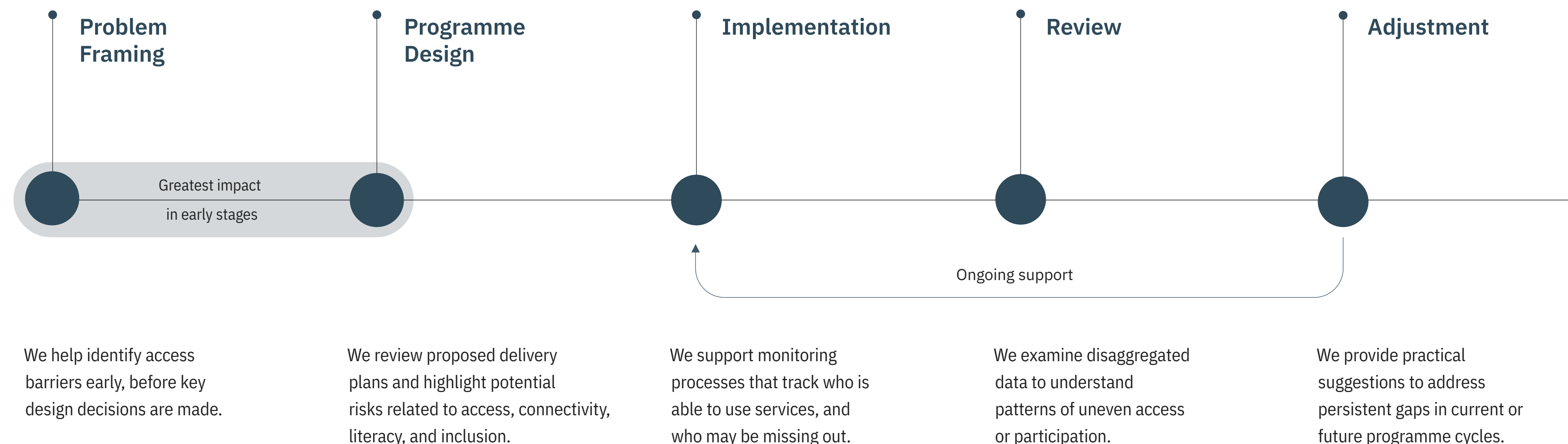
This framework supports structured discussion and early design correction.

Where we contribute

ASSESSING OUR CONTRIBUTION

Where we contribute across the programme lifecycle.

Access considerations can be integrated at multiple stages of a programme lifecycle, especially during early design and ongoing monitoring.



ASSESSING OUR CONTRIBUTION

Structural risks can be addressed before implementation.

Early design choices shape the structural conditions of equitable digital service delivery.across

[01]

Clarify design assumptions

Reviewing programme proposals can help identify implicit assumptions about connectivity, device access, digital literacy, and control over technology within households.

This can make exclusion risks visible before funding or implementation.

[02]

Benchmark against inclusion standards

Programmes can be compared against defined accessibility and equity criteria, including usability thresholds, cost barriers, gendered access constraints, and language considerations.

Findings can inform practical design adjustments.

[03]

Strengthen monitoring & feedback loops

Inclusion indicators can be integrated into existing monitoring frameworks.

This helps identify emerging access gaps and supports timely adjustment.

APPLIED EXAMPLE

Small structural shifts can prevent large access gaps.

A national digital health programme in East Africa introduced an online booking system for primary care clinics.

The aim was to reduce waiting times, especially in urban and semi-urban areas.

Before structural review

[01] Appointment booking available online only

[02] SMS-based identity verification required

[03] Text-heavy interface

[04] Assumed individual smartphone access

[05] Monitoring tracks total bookings only

After structured access review

[01] Offline booking channel introduced (community hubs / assisted sign-up)

[02] Alternative ID pathways defined

[03] Simplified interface language

[04] Shared-device use considered in design

[05] Monitoring disaggregated by access pathway

We strengthen programme design
before exclusion becomes visible.

Evidence & scope

ASSESSING OUR REACH

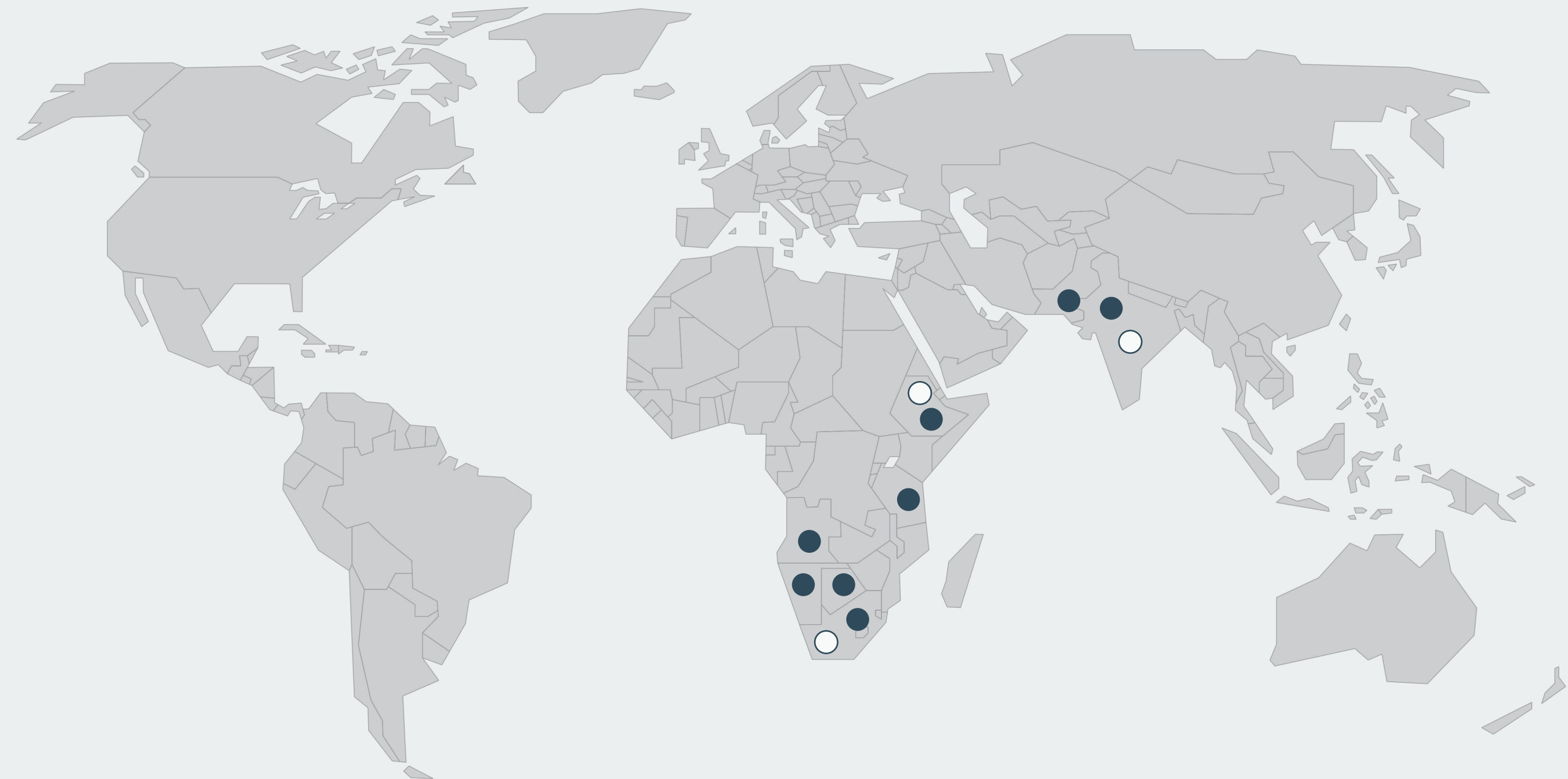
Our work spans multiple national contexts.

Where we work

Since 2022, The Digital Access Advisory Group has supported digital access programmes in low-connectivity settings across Sub-Saharan Africa and South Asia.

We prioritise contexts where structural barriers risk exclusion before implementation begins.

12 ENGAGEMENTS
ACROSS 6 COUNTRIES



- Active advisory engagement
- Framework development only

ASSESSING OUR REACH

Our experience across digital inclusion programmes.

Scope of partnership

Since 2022, the Digital Access Advisory Group has worked with partners on digital access programmes in low-connectivity settings, supporting early design, implementation, and review.

Programme Categories

Advisory Domain	Programmes Supported	Regions	Stage
Connectivity & Infrastructure Risk	12	6 countries	Pre-design
Financial Access Systems	8	4 countries	Implementation
Health Service Access Platforms	6	5 countries	Evaluation
Agricultural Information Networks	9	7 countries	Design & Scale

14 *assessment frameworks*

44 *programme reviews*

22 *risk assessments*

18 *monitoring systems*